having set the Australians a target of 348 on a turning track. It was certainly one of my better hundreds and what made the sensation sweeter was that we proceeded to bowl the Australians out for 168, with Kumble taking four wickets, and we won the match by 179 runs. It was a tremendous start and, to add to my delight, I was Man of the Match. I had made up for getting out to Warne cheaply in the first innings of the match.

Importantly, we had performed as a unit and most of the senior members had played their parts to perfection. Anil had taken eight wickets in the game while Navjot Sidhu, opening the batting, had done a good job in both innings. He had attacked Warne from the start of our second innings and had set the game up for the other batsmen. Rahul too batted well in each innings and pocketed a couple of important catches at slip. We had shown good fighting spirit and that, more than anything, augured well for the team for the second Test match at Eden Gardens in Kolkata later that month.

Second Test, Kolkata, 18–21 March 1998

If Chennai was a rollercoaster, we were in control in Kolkata from the start. Australia won the toss at Eden Gardens but failed to press home an early advantage, losing four top-order wickets within the first hour of play. Srinath bowled a fine opening spell to take three wickets and Sourav too chipped in with the wicket of Mark Taylor. Despite a brief period of Australian resurgence under Steve Waugh and Ricky Ponting, we kept our nerve and bowled them out for 233 in the first innings.

Our batsmen followed up with some big runs and for a rare occasion in Test cricket all first five batsmen passed 75, with Azhar going on to score a hundred at his favourite venue. I scored 79 and once again took the attack to Shane Warne, who went wicketless in his forty-two overs, conceding 147 runs. The plan against Warne was working and without his wickets the Australians were in trouble. I remember one particular shot against Warne on day two. In my determination to attack him, I hadn’t noticed that it was the last over before tea and I hit him for a big six over long on, which I normally wouldn’t have risked so close to a break. It just goes to show how hard you had to concentrate to cope with Warne.